

Monrovia Studies Space Mystery

By JOE BLACKSTOCK
Staff Writer

A large glowing object, looking like two inverted saucers, lit up the sky above Roswell, N.M. one summer night in 1947, and then crashed on a ranch outside of town.

A flying saucer? A meteor? An aircraft? Swamp gas? Someone's imagination?

Lee Graham of Monrovia is convinced it was truly a craft from another world. And he's devoted hundreds of hours of his free time trying to prove it.

Don't get the wrong idea. Graham, 49, isn't one of those wingnuts who write in the Star or the National Enquirer about being kidnapped by little green men for a joyride on a flying saucer.

He is an electronics systems research technician at Aerojet Electro-systems in Azusa and has worked in the aerospace industry since 1956.

He's researched the Roswell incident with the preciseness of an historian, meticulously filling a half-dozen notebooks with clippings, letters, articles and other data related to what happened that July night and the events following.

And he firmly believes the incident was no science fiction story, that some object from beyond Earth landed, with its remains being suppressed by the government for nearly four decades.

"It's definite for me that they exist," said Graham, who until recently followed his religious upbringing that said there was no other life in the universe.



Valley Views

He first heard about the Roswell incident from a fellow worker — a Carl Johnson — when both worked at Hycon Manufacturing Co., an aerospace firm in Monrovia.

Johnson reportedly told Graham and others he had been privy to the Roswell artifacts while a field representative of Hycon at Wright-Patterson Air Force Base in Ohio in the 1960s.

When he first heard about it from Johnson, Graham didn't immediately believe the story.

It wasn't until he read a 1979 article in the National Enquirer about the crash that he changed his mind.

The article said Sen. Barry Goldwater, R-Arizona, who had heard rumors the remains of the craft were kept in a secret room at Wright-Patterson, was denied access to or any information about the materials.

He started believing at that point, especially when he got a letter from Goldwater confirming he was denied access because the room "was classified above Top Secret."

Graham will tell you that following the crash near Roswell, Army Air Force personnel took charge of the

remains and an announcement was made that it was indeed a flying saucer, setting off quite a chain reaction.

The phones at the air base at Roswell starting ringing off the hook with calls coming in from as far away as Hong Kong. Then, according to Graham, the military retracted the saucer claim, saying it was only a weather balloon.

Graham said an officer — Walter Haut, now a civilian living in Roswell — told him last summer he was ordered to make up the balloon story to quiet public inquiry.

Graham will also show you a copy of an FBI telegram he obtained revealing the remains of a "flying disc" were taken to Wright-Patterson, which was headquarters of Operation Blue Book, the Air Force's now-defunct study of UFOs.

A letter written by Dr. J. A. Marcel of Helena, Mont., son of another officer who examined the crash site and brought home some of the debris for a time, produced this information:

"Many of the remnants... had strange hieroglyphic-type writing symbols across the inner surfaces," he wrote to Graham in 1981.

"The most likely explanation (for the secrecy) is the evidence is real and they just don't want the 'horrible truth' leaked out" because it would cause panic like the Orson Wells' "War of the Worlds" radio broadcast, wrote Marcel.

For Graham, though, there's another possible explanation.

He notes Wright-Patterson has had a hand in the development of the Air

Force's secret Stealth aircraft, the super-fast reconnaissance plane with properties allowing it to "hide" from enemy radar.

"Consider this: perhaps the Air Force found the crashed saucer in 1947 and discovered it was made of a special material unknown on Earth," he hypothesized.

"I can see a committee of scientists analyzing the material so that it could be manufactured, and Stealth is the result many years later."

The craft's remains, according to Marcel, who actually touched it, were exceptionally light, similar to the Kevlar-plastics which Graham believes might be used on Stealth because of an ability to absorb or distort radar signals.

"This is just what I've pieced together; speculation in some areas, fact in others," he says frankly.

Inquiries to the government, to Sen. Goldwater and to Wright-Patterson AFB have brought denials and largely no information.

"The truth will (come) out," he said resolutely. "We're not alone in this universe. Life is intrinsic in the universe."

But where is Carl Johnson?

His co-worker who could answer some critical questions in this mystery has disappeared. Efforts by Graham to find Johnson through Hycon and its parent firm, McDonnell Douglas Aeronautics Co., have run into a dead-end.

He is determined to find Johnson and ultimately the many answers for which he has questions.

And the adventure continues.

SEE
C9 17622

SEE
C2